

AcmeLIMS

Style Guide for Technical Publications

Introduction

This style guide establishes the standards and conventions for creating technical documentation within a fictitious company AcmeLIMS. It is intended to be maintained and updated regularly to reflect lessons learned, feedback, and evolving documentation requirements.

Document Format

All documents should have the following first sections:

Cover page

The cover page must follow the format used in this document and include the company logo where applicable. As this guide has been created for a fictitious company, a company logo has not been included. The cover page must not contain a page number. For instructions on removing page numbers, see Appendix 1.

Document History

The Document History section records revisions made to the document, including version numbers, dates, authors, and a summary of the changes. Maintaining a document history helps track updates and provides an audit trail of document development.

Version	Date	Author	Description
1.0	04 Jul 2026	Clare Millerchip	Initial draft

Copyright and Disclaimer

Use the following paragraph as the Copyright Statement:

This document was created by Clare Millerchip as a technical writing portfolio sample to demonstrate documentation, information design, and content development skills.

The product, company names, workflows, and data used in this document are fictitious and have been created for demonstration purposes only. Any resemblance to real products, organisations, or systems is coincidental.

No proprietary, confidential, or employer-owned information has been used in the creation of this document.

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Table of Contents

Include a Table of Contents that lists all section headings and their corresponding page numbers. The Table of Contents page must not contain a page number. For instructions on removing page numbers, see Appendix 1.

Table of Contents

Introduction	1
Document Format	1
Cover page	1
Document History	1
Copyright and Disclaimer	1
Table of Contents	1
Intended Audience	4
Conventions Used in this Guide	4
User Interface Actions	4
Support	4
Footer Information	4
Body Text	5
Information Layout	5
Overall Process	5
Topics	6
Task Topics	6
Concept Topics	7
Reference Topics	7
Tone of Voice	8
Idioms	8
Spelling	8
Language	9
Punctuation and Grammar	10
Commas	10
Lists	10
Typeface	11
AS UI Control	11
AS User Input	11
Branding Colors	11
Notes, Cautions, and Warnings	13
Notes	13
Cautions	13
Warnings	13
Warnings can indicate the following:	13

Graphics	14
Screenshots.....	14
Image Labelling	14
Arrow Tool	16
Text Tool.....	16
Including the cursor	18
Five second delay	18
Part Screenshots	18
Review and Version Control Process	19
Document Version File.....	19
Appendix 1 – Removing page numbers	20

Intended Audience

Include a brief description of the intended audience for the document. Specify the roles, responsibilities, and level of knowledge expected of readers, along with any prerequisites required to understand or complete the tasks described.

Conventions Used in this Guide

Convention	Description
Bold text	Indicates menu options, buttons, and user interface elements.
<i>Italic text</i>	Indicates document titles, emphasis, or references to other topics.
Monospace text	Indicates text that must be entered exactly as shown.
Numbered steps	Indicates a procedure that should be completed in sequence.
Notes	Provide additional information or useful tips.
Warnings	Highlight actions that could result in data loss, configuration issues, or unexpected system behaviour.

User Interface Actions

- **Click** refers to a single click of the left mouse button.
- Touchscreen users should **tap** when instructed to click.
- Where applicable, follow the procedures described in this guide to navigate and close application windows.
- When entering information into a field, type the text exactly as specified.

Support

If you have questions that are not covered in this guide, contact your system administrator or support team.

- **Email:** support@example.com
- **Telephone:** +44 (0) 1234 567890
- **Support Hours:** Monday to Friday, 09:00–17:00 GMT

Footer Information

The pages following the cover page should all contain the document version number in the left of the footer, and a page number in the right of the footer:

AcmeLIMS Style Guide Version 1.0	4
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Body Text

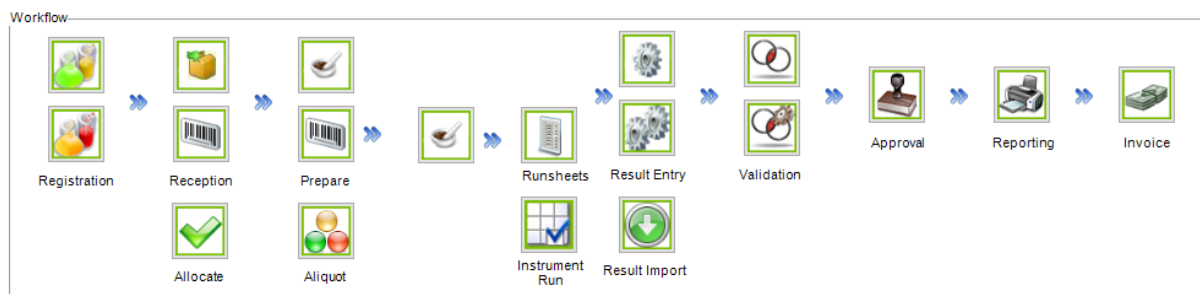
Body text contains the main content of the document and is used to communicate information, procedures, explanations, and reference material to the reader.

Information Layout

Structure content into small, focused sections with clear headings. Avoid large blocks of text and use annotated images to support explanations and improve user comprehension.

Overall Process

Provide a high-level overview of the process to help users understand the workflow, navigate the system, and identify their current stage. The overall process should be presented as a numbered list and, where possible, should not exceed nine steps. The following example illustrates how a high-level workflow can be represented using numbered process steps:



1. Registration
2. Reception
3. Preparation
4. Runsheets
5. Result Entry
6. Validation
7. Approval
8. Reports
9. Invoice

This list contains the maximum intended number of items in a list; 9. Each of these items (steps) contains sub steps that the user must complete before they can move on to the next step.

Topics

Write information using three topic types:

1. Task
2. Concept
3. Reference

Task Topics

Task topics explain actions that the user can perform with the systems and why they would want to perform them. For example, do not explain the function of a screen, tell the user why they would want to use the screen and how they would benefit from it, and what the expected outcome is.

To quote an IBM user: 'Don't tell me how it works, tell me how to use it.'

A useful analogy is a motor car. Most people who own cars do not understand how all the different components of the engine work. They understand that essentially the car will get them from A to B. They also understand how to carry out the following common tasks:

- Using the foot controls; clutch, brakes, accelerator.
- Using other controls such as windscreen wipers, headlights.
- Adjusting the seats and mirrors.
- Refuelling the car.
- Changing a tyre and what pressure the air in the tyres must be.

Task topics should include the following elements:

1. Title – Begin task titles with an action verb.
2. Short Description – must explain what the task helps users accomplish, the benefits of the task, or the purpose of the task. Do not simply repeat the title. Try to include information that will help users understand when the task is appropriate or why the task is necessary. Avoid stating the obvious, such as "You can use XYZ to do A" as the only statement in the short description for Task A. In some cases, add more information about why the task is beneficial. Avoid starting short descriptions with phrases such as "This topic describes..." or "This topic is about..."
3. Pre-requisites - for example what they must have already configured/set up prior to carrying out the task. Also, for example, what type of user they must be logged in as (do they require administrator privileges)?
4. Task steps – each sub task the user must complete, in sequential order, labelled as numbers. The steps must be clear, concise and match the construction of the other steps to make them easy to follow and understand.
5. Expected outcome - the expected outcome for the task so the user can see if they were successful or not.

6. What to do next - the steps or tasks that the user should do after the successful completion of the current task, with a link to the next topic.

Concept Topics

Concept topics describe the principles behind something, providing more detail to the user. Separate this information from task topics so the tasks remain focused.

Link conceptual information from task topics.

Reference Topics

Reference topics must be placed in appendices and referenced from other topics.

Reference topics provide data in support of the performance of a task. Reference topics may provide lists and tables that include product specifications, parts lists, constraints on use or performance, and other data that is often “looked up” rather than memorized. A reference topic may also describe regular constituents of a subject or product, such as commands in a programming language or required tools for a series of maintenance tasks.

Reference topics provide quick access to fact-based information. In technical information, reference topics are used to list product specifications and parameters, provide essential data, and provide detailed information on subjects such as the commands in a programming language. Reference topics may hold any subject matter that has regular content, such as ingredients for food in recipes, bibliographic lists, catalogue items, and so on.

Tone of Voice

Write in the active voice, for example 'click on the button' not 'the button must be clicked'.

The following words sum up the tone of voice we want to convey: Knowledgeable, Reliable, Proactive, Accurate.

The tone of Technical Publications must reflect the audience to which it is communicating. Appropriate language and terminology must be used. Bear in mind that users of the software are intelligent business professionals such as scientists and veterinarians. The underlying tone must remain serious, and information must be written in relevant detail to make it credible to the readership. Do not include light or funny anecdotes that may offend.

Idioms

Avoid idioms because they do not translate effectively and may confuse international readers. An idiom is a phrase or expression whose meaning cannot be understood from the individual words alone. For example, "I spilled the beans" means to reveal a secret, not literally to spill beans. Idioms can be confusing for international readers and may not translate accurately into other languages.

Spelling

While AcmeLIMS is a UK company, its key growth market is the USA. Where possible the default spelling in Technical Publications is written using US spelling, for example color, capitalization.

However, some labels in Screenshots and references to User Interfaces must be consistent to what gets displayed in the Software so the user can easily identify these areas. Where a term appears in the application user interface, use the exact spelling displayed in the software. Terms must be consistent with the software and screenshots where English is used. Always refer to the screen control with the exact same spelling.

Language

The following table details the language to use when writing AcmeLIMS technical publications:

Word/phrase	Explanation
etc...	Do not use 'etc...' because this is vague. Either explain all the items/concepts, or if there are too many don't use 'etc....'
Please	Do not write 'please'.
Needs to be	Do not write 'needs to be' say 'must'.
Allows you to	Writing, for example, 'the application allows you to' implies anthropomorphism (that the application has human characteristics, that it allows something). Instead, re-phrase to something like 'you can use the application to...'
i.e.	Some foreign audiences may not understand i.e. or what it stands for. Write 'for example' instead.
e.g.	Some foreign audiences may not understand e.g. or what it stands for. Write 'for example' instead.
Should	Use 'should' for something that may be recommended but is not mandatory. Use 'should' for best practice recommendations.
Must	Use 'must' for mandatory requirements.
Thus, Pertaining to	Avoid the use of old-style words such as 'thus'; use 'like this'. Instead of 'pertaining to', write "in relation to" or 'in reference to'.
In order to	Do not use, these words are superfluous.
If.... then	Do not use 'if' and 'then' for example in a coding style. Just use 'if' and describe what happens.
Ensure	Do not use 'ensure', use 'make sure'.
Three Letter Acronyms	Spell out TLAs (Three Letter Acronyms) when first used and then use the acronym from that point on.

Punctuation and Grammar

Use only one space after a full stop, not two.

Commas

Use the Oxford comma (also called a serial comma) to separate items in a sentence, for example 'do this, then this, then this' not 'do this, then this then this' because the end of the sentence could be grouped, and understood, as one thing.

Lists

Use numbered lists for procedures.

Use bullet lists for items that have the same priority.

Use a colon at the end of the sentence that precedes the list, not a semi colon. For example, to do x complete the following steps:

Typeface

The following typefaces are to be used in Technical Publications. They have been configured as styles in this document and should be used for all other documentation:

Style	Typeface	Size	Color	Alignment	Weight
AS Front Page Heading 1	Calibri	36	Dark blue 0e3b60	Center	Normal
AS Front Page Heading 1	Calibri	28	Dark blue 0e3b60	Center	Normal
AS Heading 1	Calibri	24	Dark blue 0e3b60	Left	Normal
AS Heading 2	Calibri	16	Dark blue 0e3b60	Left	Normal
AS Heading 3	Calibri	11	Dark blue 0e3b60	Left	Normal
AS Body Text	Calibri	11	Automatic (black)	Left	Normal
AS Table Heading	Calibri	11	Dark blue	Center	Bold
AS Table Text	Calibri	11	Automatic (black)	Center	
AS UI Control	Calibri	11	Automatic (black)	Left	Bold
AS User Input	Courier New	11	Automatic (black)	Left	Normal

AS UI Control

Screen items and areas that the user must click are represented in **bold**. This is indicated by the style AS UI Control in the above table.

For example:

Menu items on the graphical interface are represented in **bold type**.

AS User Input

Text to be typed in is represented in `courier new` using the exact text (no more or no less) in the correct case. This is indicated by the style AS User Input in the above table.

For example:

When you are asked to type text into a field, the text to be typed is `represented like this`.

Branding Colors

Use the following branding colors:

- Dark Blue = 0e3b60
- Light Blue = 00a0dd

- Green = 77db43
- Purple = e21d8e

Notes, Cautions, and Warnings

Notes

A note indicates that there is no risk of system failure or any damage to the system. A note provides additional information, guidance, or context that may help users complete a task more efficiently. Without a note, a user may lose precious time and get frustrated while trying to understand why something is not working.

The text that reads Note is written in bold, lower case, with a colon. The text after the colon is

written using the normal style. Notes have the following note icon next to them:



For example:



Note: You must reboot the system for the changes to take effect.

Notes must never be written in capital letters because this implies a higher level of seriousness.

Cautions

A caution indicates something that could cause system failure, a business problem, or physical damage. A caution highlights an issue that the user must pay attention to, even if it is not a matter of life or death.

The text that reads caution is written in bold, UPPER CASE, with a colon. The text after the colon is

written using the normal style. Cautions must be accompanied by a caution icon:



For example:



CAUTION: If you do not obtain prior permission from the site manager to conduct an inspection you can be sued for trespassing and criminal conduct.

The word caution is capitalized to imply a certain level of risk.

Warnings

Warnings can indicate the following:

- Data loss
- Security risks
- Irreversible actions

The text that reads warning is written in bold, UPPER CASE with a colon. The text after the colon is

written using the normal style. Warnings must have a caution icon next to them:



For example:

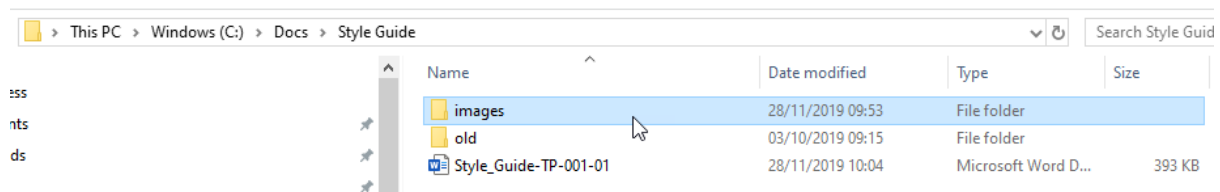


WARNING: Deleting this configuration permanently removes all associated data and cannot be undone.

Warnings are bold and capitalized to imply the highest level of risk.

Graphics

For each project, create a sub folder called images and save all graphics to here. For example:



Use SnagIt for diagrams, for example Screenshots. You must save two versions of the file:

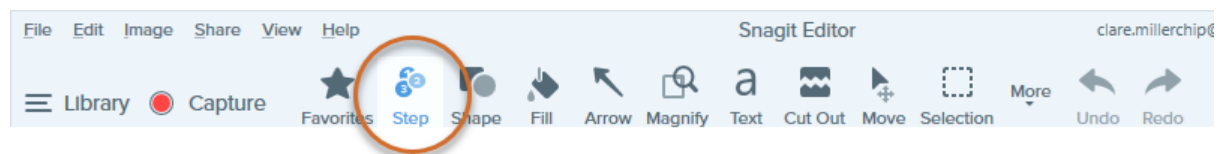
1. Xxxxx.snag – this does not flatten the file so you can still edit labels etc. Use this solely for editing elements.
2. Xxxxx.png – this flattens the file which means that the file size is smaller than a .snag file, and you can't edit label and annotations. The image is one whole thing, not made of constituent parts. Use .png files in documents to keep the overall file size down.

Screenshots

Screenshots should be captured using the Window Capture feature rather than capturing the entire screen and manually cropping the image.

Image Labelling

All images in task topics must be labelled with numbers that correspond to areas the user must click to complete the task. Use the step tool within Snag It to label images:



A color scheme has been configured in Snag It to use the AcmeLIMS colors with the step tool:



Use the dark blue with white text because this stands out on the User Interface of AcmeLIMS which is predominantly white. This is a quick and effective way of numbering a diagram to correspond with step tasks, rather than using arrows pointing to areas. Care, however, must be taken that areas are not stamped over by others (the size of the steps is configurable). The following is an example from a User Guide:

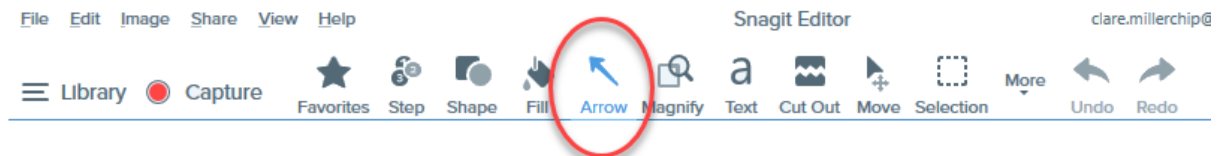
To enter the NDA level and Project Dates, complete the following steps:

1. In the **Projects Add/Edit** screen, select the NDA level from the **NDA** drop-down list, for example Red to represent an NDA level of Highly Confidential.
2. Enter the **Project Type**, for example Internal.
3. Select the **Project Start Date**, for example select today's date.
4. Enter some **Project Notes**, for example Test project for run through:



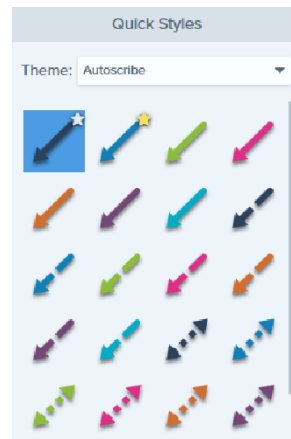
Note: Do not use the words 'do the following' before explaining the steps. Use 'complete the following steps'.

Arrow Tool



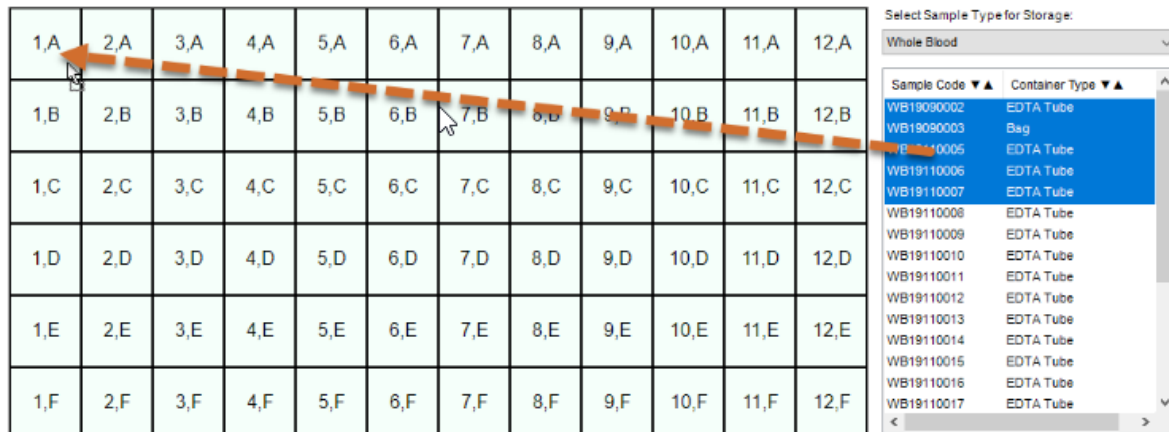
Use arrows to indicate movement.

A color scheme has been configured in Snag It to use the AcmeLIMS colors with the arrow tool:

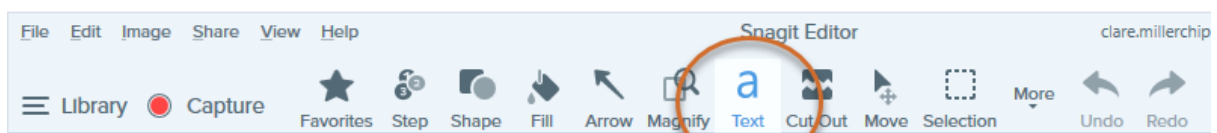


For example:

4. Drag and drop the samples to the location in which you want to store them:

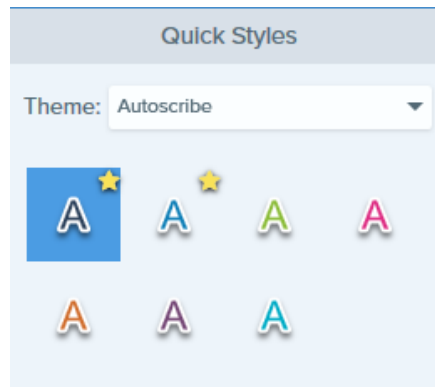


Text Tool



Use text to annotate items in a screenshot.

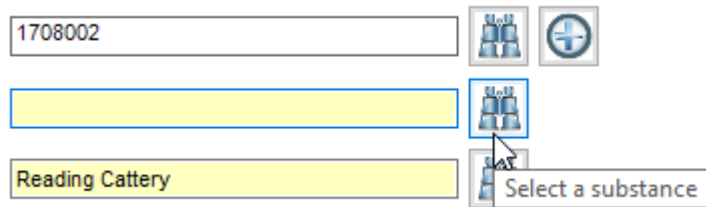
A color scheme has been configured in Snag It to use the AcmeLIMS colors with the text tool. At the time of writing it is not clear if this is needed or if it will be superfluous to text in the body of the document.



Including the cursor

This is useful if you want to display a tooltip button, or to indicate where the user is in the User Interface.

Press the [Print Screen] button before taking the screenshot to display the cursor. For example:



Five second delay

The five second delay option is useful (for example re-sizing windows in a system, or progress bars) for use with the 'All in One' option.

Part Screenshots

Because application screens may contain significant white space, it is sometimes more useful to include a part of a screenshot, for example to indicate that samples are now Tested in the Sample Result Entry screen:

Associated Tests:			
Order ▼...	TestCode ▼▲	Test Description ▼▲	Test Status ▼▲
0	DRIVECYCLE	Drive Cycle	Tested

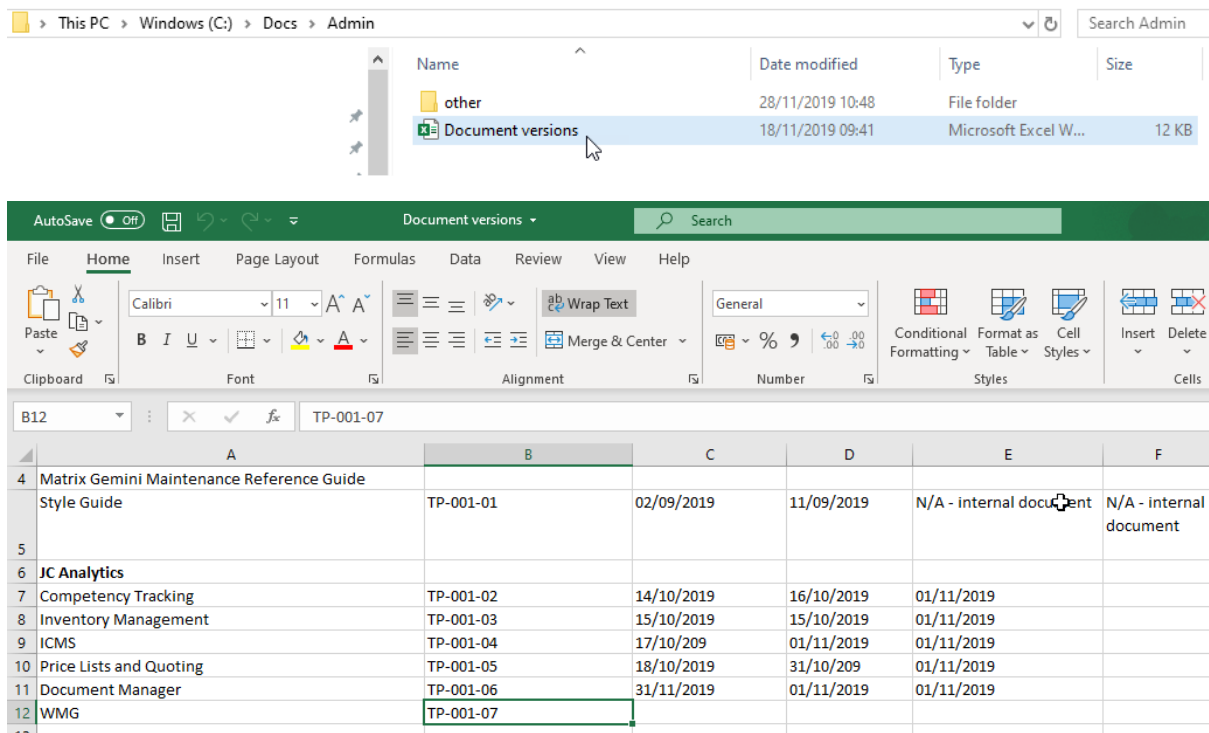
Review and Version Control Process

Document version no. TP-001-01 (TP = Technical Publication). The first number, 001, = document number, the second number 02 = release number.

1. For the first review, the document name is appended with an A, for example TP-001-01A
2. Increment the letter corresponding to each review, for example B, C, D
3. When the document is due to be released, remove the letter, so for example, the first release of the document has 01 to indicate that this is the first release of the document.
4. For the second release of the document, do the same but with 02, for example TP-002-01
5. For the first review, the name becomes TP-002-01A
6. Increment the letter for each review, for example B, C, D
7. The name of the second release of the document is TP-002-01

Document Version File

Version names are stored and maintained in a file called 'Document versions' in the Docs/Admin folder:



The top screenshot shows a Windows File Explorer window with the address bar set to 'This PC > Windows (C:) > Docs > Admin'. The file list shows a folder named 'other' and a file named 'Document versions' (Microsoft Excel Workbook, 12 KB, last modified 18/11/2019 09:41).

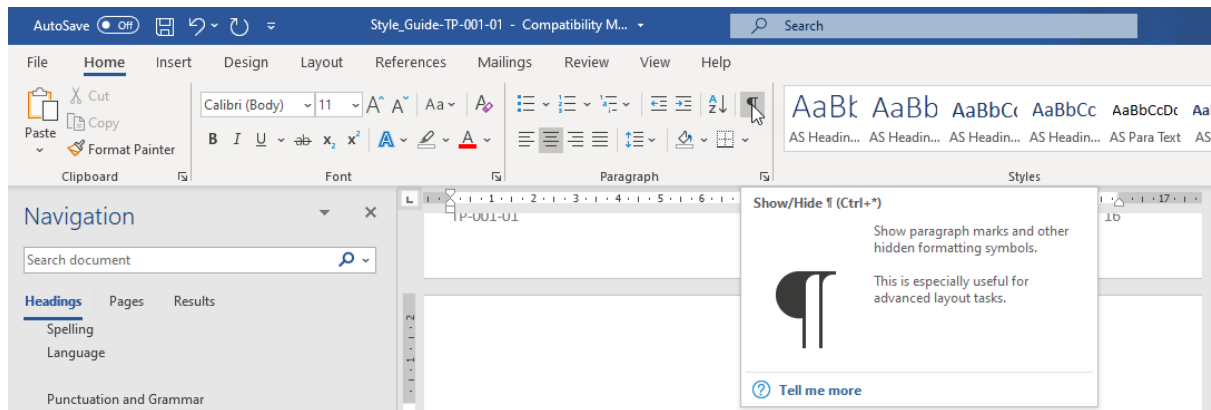
The bottom screenshot shows an Excel spreadsheet titled 'Document versions'. The spreadsheet contains the following data:

	A	B	C	D	E	F
4	Matrix Gemini Maintenance Reference Guide Style Guide	TP-001-01	02/09/2019	11/09/2019	N/A - internal document	N/A - internal document
5						
6	JC Analytics					
7	Competency Tracking	TP-001-02	14/10/2019	16/10/2019	01/11/2019	
8	Inventory Management	TP-001-03	15/10/2019	15/10/2019	01/11/2019	
9	ICMS	TP-001-04	17/10/2019	01/11/2019	01/11/2019	
10	Price Lists and Quoting	TP-001-05	18/10/2019	31/10/2019	01/11/2019	
11	Document Manager	TP-001-06	31/11/2019	01/11/2019	01/11/2019	
12	WMG	TP-001-07				

Appendix 1 – Removing page numbers

To remove the first two-page numbers in Word (the cover page and Table of Contents), complete the following steps:

1. Show paragraph formatting by clicking the Show/Hide button on the home menu:



2. Place the cursor at the start of the first heading of the page that you want the first page number to go on, for example page 3.
3. Select the menu option **Layout > Breaks > Next Page**. A new section break is added.
4. Remove any page breaks.
5. Double-click in the header or footer area on the first header in the new section where you want to display page numbers, for example page 3.
6. Turn OFF **Link to Previous** by clicking it.
7. Select **Page Number > Format Page Numbers**.
8. To start numbering with 1, select Start at, and type 1 (otherwise, Word will automatically apply the actual page number).
9. Select **OK**.
10. To remove page numbers from the previous section (section 1), select any page number in that section to highlight it and click **Delete**. All page numbers in that section will be deleted. Select **Close Header and Footer** or press Esc to exit.